The Problem of How to Interpret Wisdom Christology for New Testament Descriptions of Christ as Pre-Existent Co-Creator (DRAFT)

In the New Testament (abbr. NT) there are several verses which depict Christ as existing before the creation of the cosmos and participating in its creation as an assistant creator. E.g.,

John 1:1-3 ESV {1} In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. {2} He was in the beginning with God. {3} All things were made through him, and without him was not any thing made that was made.

1 Cor 8:6 ESV yet for us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and through whom we exist.

Col 1:16-17 ESV For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities--all things were created through him and for him. {17} And he is before all things, and in him all things hold together.

Such verses are especially favored by Homo-Ousionists for claiming that Christ is uncreated and consubstantial with God the Father. Whatever be the correct interpretation of these verses, it ought to be the Old Testament (abbr. OT) which serves as exegetical guidance. The authors of the NT typically wrote with the expectation that the audience was intimately familiar with the OT, in particular, the Greek Septuagint (abbr. LXX), which typically included the Greek translations of the Deuterocanonical books (i.e., Tobit, Judith, Wisdom of Solomon, Sirach/Ecclesiasticus, Baruch, Letter of Jeremiah, 1-4 Maccabees, 1 Esdras, Prayer of Manasseh, Psalm 151, Additions to Esther, Additions to Daniel) in addition to the Greek translation of the Tanakh (i.e., *Torah* "Law", *Nevi'im* "Prophets", *Ketuvim* "Writings"). After all, the NT was written in Greek for audiences familiar with Greek, so the natural assumption is that the audiences were expected to be familiar with the LXX, but Not necessarily familiar with the Hebrew & Aramaic texts thereof. Therefore, the LXX must have a special priority when seeking the proper interpretation of the NT.

The proper method of interpretation ought to be that one reads the LXX as if one is ignorant of the NT, and then read the NT such as to conform to one's interpretation of the LXX; and Not vice-versa by reading the NT first, and then force the OT to conform to one's understanding of the NT. The latter methodology would lead to a severe chicken & egg problem with *post-hoc* bias; the desired conclusion cannot be a starting axiom when looking at the data. One has to be uncertain about the conclusion when beginning to look at the data. Therefore, when reading verses about Christ serving as pre-existent co-creator, such as John 1:1-3, 1 Cor 8:6, Col 1:16, the interpretation ought to have a foundation in the Tanakh & Deuterocanonical books. Moreover, Paul's writings have a reputation of being difficult to read & easily misused, as warned in 2 Peter 3:16.

2 Pet 3:15-16 ESV {15} And count the patience of our Lord as salvation, just as our beloved brother Paul also wrote to you according to the wisdom given him, {16} as he does in all his letters when he speaks in them of these matters. **There are some things in them that are hard to understand, which the ignorant and unstable twist to their own destruction, as they do the other Scriptures.**

A simple example of this would be Paul's opposition to circumcision as described in Gal 5:2-4, which at first glance appears to be a very staunch and absolute opposition to circumcision. However, Paul's circumcising Timothy in Acts 16:3 in a time when Jewish identity was largely patrilineal instead of the later matrilineality forces the reader to reconsider

Paul's stance about circumcision. Moreover, there are also statements in Paul's writings which seem overreaching at first glance. E.g.,

Gal 3:13 ESV Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us--for it is written, "Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree"

1 Cor 8:7-9 ESV {7} However, not all possess this knowledge. But some, through former association with idols, eat food as really offered to an idol, and their conscience, being weak, is defiled. {8} Food will not commend us to God. We are no worse off if we do not eat, and no better off if we do. {9} But take care that this right of yours does not somehow become a stumbling block to the weak.

In these two examples, Paul calls Jesus a "curse" and calls it a "right" to eat foods offered to an idol. Some translations have it as a "privilege" to eat foods offered to idols. As a matter of fact, 1 Cor 8:6 is nearby, speaking of Christ's service as pre-existent co-creator. Therefore, if it is the case that 1 Cor 8:9 looks overreaching at first glance and must be reconsidered, the same could probably also be said about 1 Cor 8:6 concerning Christ's role as pre-existent co-creator. What these examples show is that the face-value meaning of Paul's writings is sometimes Not the intended meaning.

Lady Wisdom in the Tanakh and Deuterocanonical Books

The best candidate for the OT foundation and precursor of Christ's service as pre-existent co-creator is the Lady Wisdom figure of Proverbs, who is described as pre-existing the cosmos, and it can be inferred that she served as "co-creator". To be disputed, however, is whether the personhood of Lady Wisdom is literal or a non-literal personification of God's Wisdom.

Prov 3:19 ESV The LORD by wisdom founded the earth; by understanding he established the heavens.

Prov 8:22-27 ESV {22} “The LORD possessed me at the beginning of his work, the first of his acts of old. {23} Ages ago I was set up, at the first, before the beginning of the earth. {24} When there were no depths I was brought forth, when there were no springs abounding with water. {25} Before the mountains had been shaped, before the hills, I was brought forth, {26] before he had made the earth with its fields, or the first of the dust of the world. {27} When he established the heavens, I was there; when he drew a circle on the face of the deep,

The Greek word *Logos* also has a broad range of meanings, encompassing the definitions of "discourse", "narration", "explanation", "reason", "plan", and is also the origin of the English word "logic". Using the word *Logos* instead of the word *Sophia* "Wisdom" in John 1 is unsurprising, given the masculine grammatical gender of *Logos*, matching the gender of Jesus; whereas *Sophia* is grammatically feminine. Modern translations would often have v. 30 say that Lady Wisdom was like a master workman, but this translation choice is not supported by the LXX.

Prov 8:30 ESV then I was beside him, like a master workman, and I was daily his delight, rejoicing before him always,

The NT also identifies Christ as the embodiment of Lady Wisdom in several ways. E.g.,

Matt 23:34 ESV Therefore **I send you** prophets and wise men and scribes, some of whom you will kill and crucify, and some you will flog in your synagogues and persecute from town to town,

Luke 11:49 ESV Therefore also **the Wisdom of God said**, ‘I will send them prophets and apostles, some of whom they will kill and persecute,’

Luke, when reporting the statement made by Christ that is also reported in Matt 23:34, attributes the statement to Wisdom as the one speaking. That is, Luke depicts Christ as the embodiment of Wisdom, and Wisdom is the one speaking that statement. Moreover, Paul calls Jesus "the Power of God and the Wisdom of God".

1 Cor 1:24 ESV but to those who are called, both Jews and Greeks, **Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God.**

Many of the lofty statements about Christ can also be explained as descriptions of Lady Wisdom repeated as descriptions of Christ as the embodiment of Wisdom. E.g.,

- **Christ as Perfect Image, Firstborn, and Radiance of God:**
  Prov 8:22 ESV "The LORD possessed me at the beginning of his work, the first of his acts of old.
  Wis 7:26 NRSVue For she is a reflection [ἀπαύγασμα] of eternal light, a spotless mirror of the working of God, and an image of his goodness.
  Col 1:15 ESV He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation.
  Heb 1:3 ESV He is the radiance [ἀπαύγασμα] of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high,
- **Christ Having the Riches of Wisdom:**
  Prov 3:13-14 ESV Blessed is **the one who finds wisdom**, and the one who gets understanding, {14} for the gain from her is better than gain from silver and **her profit better than gold**.
  Col 2:2-3 ESV {2} that their hearts may be encouraged, being knit together in love, to reach all the **riches of full assurance of understanding and the knowledge** of God's mystery, which is Christ, {3} in whom are hidden all **the treasures of wisdom and knowledge**.
- **Christ as Life and the Only Way to the Father:**
  Prov 1:28-33 ESV {28} Then they will call upon me, but I will not answer; they will seek me diligently but will not find me. {29} Because they hated knowledge and did not choose the fear of the LORD, {30} would have none of my counsel and despised all my reproof, {31} therefore they shall eat the fruit of their way, and have their fill of their own devices. {32} For the simple are killed by their turning away, and the complacency of fools destroys them; {33} but whoever listens to me will dwell secure and will be at ease, without dread of disaster."
  Prov 8:35-36 ESV {35} **For whoever finds me finds life** and obtains favor from the Lord, {36} but he who fails to find me injures himself; all who hate me love death."
  John 14:6 ESV Jesus said to him, "I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.
- **Jesus Described as Food or Drink:**
  Sir 15:3 NRSVue She will feed him with the bread of understanding and give him the water of wisdom to drink.
  Sir 24:19-21 NRSVue {19} "Come to me, you who desire me, and eat your fill of my fruits. {20} For the memory of me is sweeter than honey and the possession of me sweeter than the honeycomb. {21} Those who eat of me will hunger for more, and those who drink of me will thirst for more.
  John 6:49-51 ESV {49} Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died. {50} This is the bread that comes down from heaven, so that one may eat of it and not die. {51} I am the living bread that came down from heaven. If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever. And the bread that I will give for the life of the world is my flesh."
- **Jesus as the Power of God and Having God's Glory Before Creation:**
  Wis 7:25 NRSVue **For she is a breath of the power of God** and a pure emanation of the glory of the Almighty; therefore nothing defiled gains entrance into her.
  John 17:5 ESV And now, Father, glorify me in your own presence with the glory that I had with you before the world existed.
  1 Cor 1:24 ESV but to those who are called, both Jews and Greeks, **Christ the power of God** and the wisdom of God.

A caveat must be kept in mind about the glory of God in John 17. In Isa 42:8 it is said that God shares his glory with no one else, yet it is said in John 17:22 that the glory given to Jesus is then given to his followers, who are creatures. To avoid a contradiction, Isa 42:8 possibly has to be interpreted as hyperbole, or something similar.

Isa 42:8 ESV I am the LORD; that is my name; my glory I give to no other, nor my praise to carved idols.

John 17:22 ESV The glory that you have given me I have given to them, that they may be one even as we are one,

The Question of Literal or Non-Literal Personification of Lady Wisdom

What remains is then a very high-stakes question: whether the personhood of Lady Wisdom is literal or a non-literal personification. If her personhood is a non-literal personification, then the descriptions of Christ as pre-existent co-creator of the cosmos must also be read as non-literal; otherwise, the interpretation of these parts of the NT would be deprived of any firm OT foundations. Recall that one ought to read the OT as if one is ignorant of the NT, and then interpret the NT in such a way as to conform to one's interpretation of the OT. If the OT foundation of Christ's service as pre-existent co-creator is Lady Wisdom of Proverbs, and if Lady Wisdom's personhood is a non-literal personification, then the descriptions of Christ as pre-existent co-creator are not describing a literal person serving as pre-existent co-creator.

A reason why one might think that Lady Wisdom is a non-literal personification of God's Wisdom is the contrast between Lady Wisdom and the so-called Lady Folly, who is also described in Proverbs near descriptions of Lady Wisdom. E.g.,

Prov 9:13 ESV {13} The woman Folly is loud; she is seductive and knows nothing. {14} She sits at the door of her house; she takes a seat on the highest places of the town, {15} calling to those who pass by, who are going straight on their way,

I don't think anyone proposess that the ancient Israelites believed in the existence of a supernatural figure called Lady Folly with literal personhood who visits high places in towns. If we say that Lady Folly is a non-literal personification of folly, then we should also say that Lady Wisdom is a non-literal personification of God's Wisdom, since the descriptions of Lady Wisdom and Lady Folly are nearby to eachother in Proverbs, sharing a similar textual context. In the NT, there are also regular people described as chosen, or given purpose and grace in Christ, before the creation of the world.

Eph 1:4 ESV even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him. In love

2 Tim 1:9 ESV who saved us and called us to a holy calling, not because of our works but because of his own purpose and grace, which he gave us in Christ Jesus before the ages began,

These serve as additional examples that descriptions of someone existing before the creation of the world do not always imply literal personhood of someone consubstantial with God the Father. Moreover, the 1534 Tyndale Bible refers to the Word in John 1 as "it" instead of "him", since the Greek grammatical gender of a word does not always match the actual gender. This serves an additional datapoint to consider for literal or non-literal personification of the co-creator verses.

John 1:1-3 Tyndale {1} In the beginnynge was the worde and the worde was with God: and the worde was God. {2} The same was in the beginnynge with God. {3} All thinges were made by **it** and with out **it** was made nothinge that was made.

Example of Another Person Described Like Lady Wisdom

In ancient Israelite tradition, Christ is not the only one described like Lady Wisdom as though he is the embodiment of Lady Wisdom. E.g.,

Sir 50:1, 5-6, 8, 10, 12 NRSVue {1} The leader of his brothers and the pride of his people was the high priest, Simon son of Onias, who in his life repaired the house and in his time fortified the temple....{5} How glorious he was as he gazed from the tent, as he came out of the house of the curtain, {6} like the morning star among the clouds, like the full moon at the festal season,... {8} like roses in the days of the spring harvest, like lilies by springs of water, like a green shoot on

Lebanon on a summer day,... {10} like an olive tree laden with fruit, and like a cypress towering in the clouds.... {12} When he received the portions from the hands of the priests, as he stood by the hearth of the altar with a garland of brothers around him, he was like a young cedar on Lebanon surrounded by the trunks of palm trees.

These descriptions of the priest Simon ben Onias are just repetitions of the descriptions of Lady Wisdom in ch. 24. E.g.,

Simon like the celestial bodies: Sir 24: 4-5 NRSVue {4} I encamped in the heights, and my throne was in a pillar of cloud. {5} Alone I compassed the vault of heaven and traversed the depths of the abyss.

Simon like fragrant vegetation in Lebanon & fruit: Sir 24:13-19 NRSVue {13} "I grew tall like a cedar in Lebanon and like a cypress on the heights of Hermon. {14} I grew tall like a palm tree in En-gedi and like rosebushes in Jericho; like a fair olive tree in the field and like a plane tree beside water I grew tall. {15} Like cassia and camel's thorn I gave forth perfume, and like choice myrrh I spread my fragrance, like galbanum, onycha, and stacte, and like the odor of incense in the tent. {16} Like a terebinth I spread out my branches, and my branches are glorious and graceful. {17} Like the vine I bud forth delights, and my blossoms become glorious and abundant fruit. [v. 18 has disputed variations] {19} "Come to me, you who desire me, and eat your fill of my fruits.

Of course, nobody thinks Simon ben Onias is a co-equal, consubstantial, eternally-generated person of God. What this demonstrates is that being described like Lady Wisdom does not immediately imply that one is a literal, consubstantial, uncreated, co-creator with God the Father.

Lady Wisdom as the Personification of Torah

Lady Wisdom is also depicted as the personification of the Torah in Sirach 24:23 & Baruch 4:1.

Sir 24:22-23 NRSVue {22} Whoever obeys me will not be put to shame, and those who work with me will not sin." {23} All this is the book of the covenant of the Most High God, the law that Moses commanded us as an inheritance for the congregations of Jacob.

Bar 3:37-4:1 NRSVue {3:37} He found the whole way to knowledge and gave her to his servant Jacob and to Israel, whom he loved. {3:38} Afterward she appeared on earth and lived with humankind. {4:1} She is the book of the commandments of God, the law that endures forever. All who hold her fast will live, and those who forsake her will die.

In the Genesis Rabbah commentaries, the Torah is also described like a cosmic instrument of creation when God created the cosmos, much like the descriptions of Christ as co-creator in the NT, precisely because of the Lady Wisdom tradition.

Gen Rabbah 1:1 Rabbi Hoshaya the Great began: "I was with Him as an *amon*, a delight day after day…" (Proverbs 8:30) - *amon* means a child's caretaker, *amon* means covered, *amon* means hidden, and some say *amon* means greatness. *Amon* means a child's caretaker, as it says: "As a caretaker [omen] carries a nursing child" (Numbers 11:12).... The Torah is saying: 'I was the tool of craft of the Holy One blessed be He.' The way of the world is that when a flesh-and-blood king builds a palace he does not build it based on his own knowledge, but rather based on the knowledge of an artisan. And the artisan does not build it based on his own knowledge, but rather, he has [plans on] sheets and tablets by which to ascertain how he should build its rooms, how he should build its doors. So too, the Holy One blessed be He looked in the Torah and created the world. The Torah says: "*Bereshit* God created" (Genesis 1:1), and *reshit* is nothing other than the Torah, as it says: "The Lord made me at the beginning of [*reshit*] His way" (Proverbs 8:22).

Notice that this commentary references Prov 8:30, 22, connecting the Torah to the Lady Wisdom descriptions. The Torah described like a blueprint for creation could also be compared to the Platonist concept of the World of Forms, in which reside the so-called perfect forms of all things, of which the things in the sensible world are imperfect copies. Indeed, when it is said that Jesus was in the form (*morphē,* the same Greek word as that of "form" in Plato's World of Forms) of

God in Philip 2:6, it could plausibly be describing Jesus as the blueprint of the creation of Adam in Gen 1:26, since it is said that Adam was made in the image of God.

Gen 1:26 ESV Then God said, “Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. And let them have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over the livestock and over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth.”

Philip 2:6 ESV who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped,

But unlike Adam, Christ did not attempt to be "like God" during his ministry, whereas Adam & Eve disobeyed in the Garden, and ate the forbidden fruit after being persuaded by the serpent to try being "like God".

Gen 3:5 ESV For God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be **like God**, knowing good and evil.”

Therefore, when it is said in Philippians 2:6 that Christ was in the form of God, it is likely another example of Christ described like Lady Wisdom. When it is said that Christ did not treat equality with God as *harpagmon* (translated as "thing to be grasped" or "robbery"), it is comparing & contrasting with Adam & Eve's disobedience when they attempted to be "like God", eating the forbidden fruit. Indeed, the so-called Adam Christology (i.e., describing Jesus as the 2nd Adam, with obedience instead of disobedience) is a common theme in the NT; e.g.,

1 Cor 15:21-22, 45 ESV {21} For as by a man came death, by a man has come also the resurrection of the dead. {22} For as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive.... {45} Thus it is written, "The first man Adam became a living being"; the last Adam became a life-giving spirit.

Comparison with *Prayer of Joseph*

Even if we are to say that Christ had literal personhood before the creation of the world, this still is not enough evidence for the doctrine of Homo-Ousionism. In late 2nd-Temple or early Post-2nd-Temple Jewish literature, existing before the creation of the cosmos does not immediately imply Eternal Generation or consubstantiality with God the Father. Origen, the pioneer of the doctrine of Eternal Generation, quoted a now-lost work called the *Prayer of Joseph* in his commentary of the Gospel of John Book II, ch. 25, saying that John the Baptist could possibly be described like the Genesis patriarchs described as existing before creation in the *Prayer of Joseph*.

(Origen, *Commentary on the Gospel of John*, Book II, ch. 25) [Chapter Title: Argument from the Prayer of Joseph, to Show that the Baptist May Have Been an Angel Who Became a Man.] As we are now engaged with what is said of John, and are asking about his mission, I may take the opportunity to state the view which I entertain about him.... And who would not be moved at the thought of his leaping for joy when yet in the belly, surpassing as he did the common nature of man? Should the piece entitled *The prayer of Joseph*, one of the apocryphal works current among the Hebrews, be thought worthy of credence, this dogma will be found in it clearly expressed. Those at the beginning, it is represented, having some marked distinction beyond men, and being much greater than other souls, because they were angels, they have come down to human nature. Thus Jacob says: "I, Jacob, who speak to you, and Israel, I am an angel of God, a ruling spirit, and Abraham and Isaac were created before every work of God; and I am Jacob, called Jacob by men, but my name is Israel, called Israel by God, a man seeing God, because I am the first-born of every creature which God caused to live." And he adds: "When I was coming from Mesopotamia of Syria, Uriel, the angel of God, came forth, and said, I have come down to the earth and made my dwelling among men, and I am called Jacob by name. He was angry with me and fought with me and wrestled against me, saying that his name and the name of Him who is before every angel should be before my name. And I told him his name and how great he was among the sons of God; Are you not Uriel my eighth, and I am Israel and archangel of the power of the Lord and a chief captain among the sons of God? Am not I Israel, the first minister in the sight of God, and I invoked my God by the inextinguishable name?" It is likely that this was really

said by Jacob, and was therefore written down, and that there is also a deeper meaning in what we are told, "He supplanted his brother in the womb."

Regardless of the correctness of Origen's ideas, his quotation from the *Prayer of Joseph* shows that in late 2nd-Temple or early Post-2nd-Temple Jewish literature, it is possible for someone to be described as "firstborn" and existing before the creation of the world and still Not consubstantial with God the Father. However, John 1:3 strongly suggests that God's speech must be uncreated, a doctrine that is affirmed in Sunni Islam as well. Nonetheless, affirming that God's Word must be uncreated does not immediately imply that the personhood of God's Word is also uncreated.

Two-Stage Logos Theology

Before the doctrine of Eternal Generation, it used to be common for early Christian scholars to have the so-called Two-Stage Logos Theology, which posits that the Logos, in its 1st phase of existence, was an impersonal attribute within God, anterior to being brought forth and gaining a distinct personhood in the 2nd phase of existence. This explanation is also one of the oldest interpretations of John 1.[1] E.g.,

(Theophilus, *To Autolycus,* Book II, ch. 10) but he that is uncreated stands in need of nothing. God, then, having His own Word internal **within His own bowels**, begot Him, emitting Him along with His own wisdom before all things. He had this Word as a helper in the things that were created by Him, and by Him He made all things.

(Theophilus, *To Autolycus,* Book II, ch. 22) And hence the holy writings teach us, and all the spirit-bearing [inspired] men, one of whom, John, says, "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God," [John 1:1] showing that at first God was alone, and the Word in Him. Then he says, "The Word was God; all things came into existence through Him; and apart from Him not one thing came into existence."

To avoid a Modalist/Sabellian heresy, the meaning of the word "God" in the 3rd clause of John 1:1 must have a different meaning than "God" in the 2nd clause, which in the 2nd clause is synonymous to God the Father. Therefore, when it is said that "at first God was alone" in *To Autolycus* II.22, it means that God the Father was at first alone. In this document, Theophilus made a distinction between *Logos Endiathetos* "Logos in-dwelling" and *Logos Prophorikos* "Logos uttered/brought forth". Moreover, the LXX translations of both Prov 8:22 and Sir 24:9 have the Greek word *ektisen* "he/she/it created" to describe Lady Wisdom coming into existence. This Greek verb allows us to posit that the personhood of Lady Wisdom was created posterior to the Wisdom being brought forth from God, even though we say that God's Wisdom itself must be uncreated; that is, God's impersonal attribute of Wisdom is uncreated, whereas the personhood of Lady Wisdom, who embodies God's externalized Word & Wisdom, was created posterior to the Wisdom being brought forth from God. Disputing this translation of *ektisen* would amount to favoritism in the Christian exegesis of the OT, since the authority of the LXX translation of *ha-almah* to *parthenos* in Isaiah 7:14 is upheld to support the doctrine of Virgin Birth, and it was already explained in the beginning of our discussion that the LXX ought to have a special priority as exegetical guidance for the NT.

Athanasius also did not dispute this translation choice, but he interpreted *ektisen* as referring to the acquisition of Christ's human nature at the Incarnation.

(Athanasius, *Discourse II Against the Arians,* ch. 19 §46) Such then being the difference between 'the creatures' and the single word 'He created,' if you find anywhere in divine Scripture the Lord called 'creature,' produce it and fight; but if it is nowhere written that He is a creature, only He Himself says about Himself in the Proverbs, 'The Lord created me,'

[1] For details of Two-Stage Logos Theology, see Wolfson, Harry A. “Clement of Alexandria on the Generation of the Logos.” *Church History* 20, no. 2 (June 1951): 72–81. https://doi.org/10.2307/3162135.

shame upon you, both on the ground of the distinction aforesaid and for that the diction is like that of proverbs; and accordingly let 'He created' be understood, not of His being a creature, but of that human nature which became His, for to this belongs creation.

This explanation by Athanasius, however, would be bypassing the plain meaning of the last portion of Prov 8:22 "the first of his acts of old", which has the context of something happening at the very beginning, instead of happening at Christ's Incarnation. However, saying that the person of Christ was both created and pre-existent co-creator encounters the obstacle of Isaiah 44:24.

Isa 44:24 ESV Thus says the LORD, your Redeemer, who formed you from the womb: "I am the LORD, who made all things, who **alone** stretched out the heavens, who spread out the earth **by myself**,

Keeping the plain meaning of this verse would force a dichotomy that either Christ is consubstantial with God the Father, serving as co-creator with Him, or that the correct Christology is lower than Arianism (i.e., that the verses about Christ serving as co-creator of the cosmos are non-literal). An ontologically subordinationist high Christology like Arianism would bypass the plain meaning of this verse, which has the words "alone" and "by myself", giving the strong suggestion that there was No ontologically subordinate co-creator of the cosmos. However, there is a way of bypassing the plain meaning of Isaiah 44:24 by comparing to verses such as the following:

Isa 43:11 ESV I, I am the LORD, and besides me there is no savior [*mowoshiyaʿ* מושיע].

Judg 3:9 ESV But when the people of Israel cried out to the LORD, the LORD raised up a deliverer [*mowoshiyaʿ* מושיע] for the people of Israel, who saved them, Othniel the son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother.

Isaiah 43:11 gives the impression that only God saves, but Judges 3:9 describes Othniel as Israel's savior. This serves as an example of the Bible saying that only God does such-and-such an action, but a created entity in another verse could be described as doing the same action, serving as God's instrument of doing the action. A related verse is Gen 1:26, which is commonly interpreted as alluding to a co-creator of mankind, using plural grammatical forms.

Gen 1:26 ESV Then God said, "Let us make man in **our image, after our likeness**. And let them have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over the livestock and over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth."

Gen 1:26, however, comes after the verses about the creation of animals, and this chapter does not specify when God created the angels. Therefore, Gen 1:26 is not evidence that the co-creator of mankind existed before the creation of the cosmos, since one could simply posit that the co-creator of mankind alluded to in this verse was created after the creation of heaven & earth, and before the creation of humans, and therefore did not serve as co-creator of heaven & earth.

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